# **Case 3:** Ethics of Care Practice


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*A portfolio examining care ethics across engineering practice, relational obligations, moral judgment, and education.*

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**Good Care in Engineering & Computing**

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**Bridging Education & Ethics of Care Practice**

*"Care is not a soft ideal — it is the moral foundation of responsible technology and professional practice."*


**References:** [1] J. C. Tronto, Moral Boundaries. New York, NY: Routledge, 1993. [2] N. Noddings, Caring, 2nd ed. Berkeley, CA: Univ. of California Press, 2013.

# **Second Slide:** Good Care in Engineering and Computing

*Context: Tronto [1] identifies four phases of care — attentiveness, responsibility, competence, and responsiveness — all directly applicable to software and systems engineering.*

## ✅ Care Is Central to Good Engineering

- Tronto [1]: engineers who listen to users build safer, more equitable systems. Ignoring vulnerability is an ethical failure.
- Inclusive design (accessibility, privacy-by-design) reflects genuine care for end users, not just compliance [1].
- Caring engineers raise concerns early (e.g., AI bias), preventing harm before deployment [2].

## ❌ Care Conflicts with Engineering Efficiency

- Engineering culture prizes speed and scalability; care-centred approaches can increase cost and slow delivery [2].
- Friedman [2]: ACM/IEEE codes already set ethical standards — an additional care framework risks role ambiguity.
- Care judgments are subjective and particular; engineering needs reproducible, universal standards.

💡 *Good engineering IS an act of care. Technical excellence without human attentiveness is negligence with better tools.*

**References:** [1] J. C. Tronto, Moral Boundaries: A Political Argument for an Ethic of Care. New York, NY: Routledge, 1993. [2] B. Friedman, "Value-Sensitive Design," Interactions, vol. 3, no. 6, pp. 16–23, 1996.

# **Third Slide:** Relational Ethics: Care Beyond Humans

*Context: Traditional care ethics focused on human relationships. Relational ethics expands moral concern to animals, ecosystems, AI agents, and future generations.*

## ✅ Our Moral Circle Must Expand

- Noddings [1]: care originates in relationships — our relationships now extend to living systems and non-human worlds.
- Climate change shows human flourishing is inseparable from ecological health; caring for nature is relational self-preservation [1].
- AI ethics increasingly recognises obligations to entities that respond to care — robots, ecosystems, digital systems [2].

## ❌ Expanding Care Dilutes Its Core

- Held [2]: care is grounded in concrete, emotional, particular relationships. Abstract extension to all life risks losing its relational core.
- Unlimited moral expansion creates paralysis — if everything demands care, the concept becomes operationally meaningless [2].
- Prioritizing non-human entities can divert attention from urgent human deficits: poverty, healthcare, labour exploitation.

💡 *Expanding care beyond humans is not dilution — it is maturation. A relational ethics that ignores ecosystems is incomplete by its own standards.*

**References:** [1] N. Noddings, Caring, 2nd ed. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 2013. [2] V. Held, The Ethics of Care: Personal, Political, and Global. Oxford, UK: Oxford University Press, 2006.

# **Fourth Slide:** Moral Judgments About Care

*Context: Gilligan [1] challenges Kohlberg [2] — arguing care-based reasoning is not a lower moral stage but a distinct, equally valid moral voice rooted in relationships and context.*

## ✅ Care Is a Valid Moral Framework

- Gilligan [1]: women's relational moral reasoning is qualitatively different from — not inferior to — justice-based reasoning.
- Care judgments integrate emotional intelligence and situational nuance that abstract rules miss, producing more humane outcomes [1].
- In nursing, teaching, and social work, care-based judgment already drives best-practice professional standards [1].

## ❌ Care Alone Is Insufficient

- Kohlberg [2]: justice principles provide universal, scalable standards that particular care relationships cannot replicate.
- Care may favour those close to us, introducing moral partiality and reinforcing racial, class, and gender inequities [2].
- Systemic change — abolition, civil rights, gender equality — required principled universal frameworks, not care relationships alone.

💡 *Care and justice are complementary, not competing. Moral maturity integrates relational attentiveness with principled fairness.*

**References:** [1] C. Gilligan, In a Different Voice. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1982. [2] L. Kohlberg, The Philosophy of Moral Development. San Francisco, CA: Harper & Row, 1981.

# **Fifth Slide:** Bridging Education and Ethics of Care Practice

*Context: Should care ethics be formally embedded in engineering and computing curricula? Can care be taught as a core professional competency?*

## ✅ Care Must Be Taught Systematically

- Noddings [1]: caring classroom relations model the ethics students must later practise — education is itself a care practice.
- Case studies, service learning, and ethics audits develop moral imagination: the ability to foresee impact on vulnerable users [2].
- STEM graduates without care competencies build harmful systems. Education is the earliest and most cost-effective intervention [1].

## ❌ Institutional Care Risks Becoming Performative

- Tronto [2]: formalizing care risks reducing it to a checkbox — performative compliance rather than genuine moral formation.
- Curricula are already overloaded; a one-credit ethics module may marginalize care as a 'soft skill' rather than integrate it [2].
- Care is cultivated through mentorship and lived experience — formal instruction alone cannot produce the empathetic practitioner.

💡 *Education cannot manufacture care, but it can create conditions for it to flourish. Reflective practice bridges theory to genuine care.*

**References:** [1] N. Noddings, The Challenge to Care in Schools, 2nd ed. New York, NY: Teachers College Press, 2005. [2] J. C. Tronto, Caring Democracy. New York, NY: NYU Press, 2013.